Scribes Writers Group
Estelle El-Hai
Word count: 751
August, 2003 submission

THE OTHER LIST

Thank you Mr. Schindler for supplying the list that saved hundreds of lives. We will forever honor your memory for that historical favor to mankind. However, it's time for another list to take the limelight. I will explain....

When Sam and I moved from southern California to Fair Oaks in 1986, we bought a wonderful home on Lei Street. It had an indoor arboretum, with graceful trees reaching up to the cathedral-like sky light. We added an indoor hot tub that adjoined our master bedroom, that could hold six happy soakers. The walls were completely mirrored and adorned with red and blue lights which made all visitors gasp when they were turned on; they, as well as the lights. Everything in our new home was perfect, with one exception. We did not have a piano.

As a youngster, Sam developed a very respectable embouchure when he studied and played the trumpet. This not only added to his musical skills, but helped make him a real good kisser. My not so famous claim to fame was the piano, which I began at age eight. My piano teacher, Miss Gershwin, AKA Gershowitz, pencilled in every note for me, to speed my progress, and impress my parents. I relied on this crutch and did not develop important music reading skills. This turned out to be a benefit in Fair Oaks. Here's how.... (I became a good kisser in spite of it all.)

We were shopping at CostCo where they were featuring digital pianos that week. The representative was playing a beautiful full length instrument and it sounded like a complete orchestra. I was

completely enthralled and was invited to sit down and give it a try. With some embarrassment, I explained that I could not read music readily. The salesman was overjoyed with the news, and exclaimed,

"This is precisely for you. Let me show you why."

He quickly put a music book, called "Fake Music" on the sheet supporter, and explained how it worked. As long as one could read the right hand melody, which I easily accomplished, all I needed to do was plunk down one specified left hand note, and out came the perfect chord. I could choose the rhythm, the music style, the instruments and become a musical genius!

Sam couldn't help but get caught up in my sheer excitement and insisted that we buy the piano. I eagerly agreed and jumped up and down like an idiot. The delighted rep, whom I was already slightly in love with, though of course Sam always came first, showed me how to get these "easy" music albums.

Before I knew it, I possessed all of my golden oldies, Sinatra favorites, big band jewels, and songs that I had been singing all my life. I was in joyland and played music every day. I even found easy versions of classical numbers that I always adored. After a short while, the albums that I accumulated exceeded fifty, and Sam built a special cabinet to hold them all. Oftentimes, there was a particular melody that I wanted, as my friends asked for requests. Sam saw the need and got to work on a computerized, alphabetized table of contents. He spent hours accounting for each song in each book. The good guy categorized the song titles, the type of music, the book titles and every possible way to find what I wanted. Each list was bound in a thick compilation and presented to grateful me. Little did I

know how valuable it would become.

One of the many pleasures I find in Sun City is the opportunity to write, produce, and/or direct various "shows". Usually, an appropriate song is suggested to spoof on an industrious idea. Lyrics are needed so that they can be augmented to fit the need. But, what were the lyrics to that great old song? Sam's list comes to the rescue. Before the discussion has even begun, the lyrics and the music are at my fingertips, and the play on words begin.

The list has helped me out in commemorating a friend's birthday, or in a "roast" for a special event. I must make additional printouts as the pages are becoming doggy-eared. These gifts from Sam have become priceless and will be helpful and appreciated for generations to come. In our family, his precious contribution will be know as our "Academy Award" winner, Sam's List.

*** finis ***